

REPLACING FLASH WITH HTML5 AND CSS3

Even though Flash can enable animated and interactive content on websites, it does have a number of drawbacks. The slow loading of Web pages and the inability of Flash content to search bots makes it necessary to replace Flash with other tools.



Making a page interactive is an important part of Web designing. Many websites have to play multimedia clips, display attractive animated pictures, collect data from visitors 'actively' and, ultimately, the creators of many Web pages want these to become useful 'Web apps'.

A few years ago, the only way to achieve these goals was using by Adobe Flash. Files created with Flash can be exported to animated GIF (used since the early days of the WWW), video and SWF (Shock Wave Flash) file formats. SWF files can act as normal programs. Hence, Flash became a favourite tool of Web designers.

Actually, the reason for the growth of Flash was that HTML did not have built-in support for multimedia (except image files) and animation. But now, with the arrival of HTML5, it is possible to handle multimedia content with the native HTML code. Yet, many people still use outdated Flash-based techniques. But why should one stick to proprietary, out-dated technology when there's an open source alternative that is simple and powerful?

By going over some comparisons and examples, let us try to learn the techniques to play multimedia files, to create animations, and to write attractive Web applications using HTML5 and CSS3 with a touch of JavaScript.

Why Flash should be replaced

If you think your work should be universally accessible, you have to forget Flash and come to HTML5. Table 1 will give you a clearer picture.

Flash-based multimedia	HTML5 media playback feature
In order to play Flash-based multimedia content, users have to install a Flash plugin on the computer. Besides, it is not universally supported—for example, some products from Apple do not allow Flash to run.	HTML5 is standard technology. So all upcoming browsers are forced to accept it (if they want to survive). Popular browsers including Mozilla Firefox and Google Chromium/Chrome already support HTML5 very well. The result is that your media will be universally playable.
Even though free SWF editors are available, professional-level SWF media can only be created using Adobe Flash. This is proprietary, commercial software that works with Microsoft Windows only.	Interactive page creation with HTML5, CSS3 and JavaScript can be done using simple text editors. Being open source technology, it is reachable universally.
Flash has been widely deprecated since the arrival of HTML5.	HTML5 is just the latest version of standard HTML, maintained by W3C.

Table 1: A comparison between Flash and HTML5

Media playback using HTML5

Before the arrival of HTML5, a Web designer had to embed an external/third-party media player into the Web page in order to play an audio or video clip. But fortunately, HTML5 comes with built-in